Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop: Extending Topological Latency from 2D Heterophilic Graphs to 3D Geometric Manifolds

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***Abstract*—Graph Neural Networks (GNNs) suffer from *over-smoothing* [10] and *heterophily failure* [4], wherein repeated aggregation collapses discriminative features and cross-class edges blur semantic boundaries. Half-Hop [5] addresses both on 2D relational graphs by inserting virtual "slow nodes" to throttle message-passing latency without modifying encoder architectures. We present two contributions: (i) a rigorous software reproduction of Half-Hop across six standard heterophilic node-classification benchmarks on GCN, GraphSAGE, and GAT; and (ii) *Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop*, a principled 3D extension for part segmentation on ShapeNet-Part [8], [9]. Our method introduces a dual-gated crease criterion combining Pauly surface variation [7] with normal disagreement, selectively inserting slow nodes at physical inter-part seams while leaving smooth intra-part surfaces fully uninhibited. A decoupled Boundary-Specific mIoU (mIoU_{bnd}) evaluation protocol isolates geometric seam quality from interior accuracy. Evaluations on rigid ShapeNet categories demonstrate substantial boundary-fidelity improvements over standard message-passing baselines, while systematic threshold ablations confirm that restricting latency modulation to genuine geometric creases effectively mitigates feature bleeding without starving smooth surface representations.**

***Index Terms*—Graph neural networks, Half-Hop, over-smoothing, heterophily, 3D point clouds, part segmentation, geometric boundary detection, EdgeConv.**

I. Introduction

GRAPH Neural Networks (GNNs) achieve strong performance on homophilic graphs but struggle under heterophily [4] and over-smoothing [1], [10]. Half-Hop [5] counters these pathologies by inserting virtual intermediate "slow nodes" ν_k along directed edges, converting each single-hop link $v_i \to v_j$ into a two-step detour $v_i \to \nu_k \leftrightarrow v_j$. This dampens feature mixing and preserves localized spectral components without altering encoder weights.

Extending Half-Hop to 3D point clouds presents a compelling frontier. Inter-part transition boundaries (e.g., where a chair leg meets a seat) represent physical edge heterophily—spatially adjacent points abruptly switch semantic labels. Yet uniform slow-node insertion across all edges would cripple rapid intra-part communication across smooth surfaces. Geometry must therefore drive where latency modulation is applied.

This paper makes three contributions:

1) **Empirical Reproduction:** A modular PyTorch Geometric [11] implementation of Half-Hop across six heterophilic benchmarks [4], reproducing connectivity and initialization ablations.
2) **Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop:** A principled 3D extension using dual-gated crease detection for part segmentation on ShapeNet-Part [8], [9].
3) **Decoupled Boundary Metric:** A novel mIoU_{bnd} protocol isolating seam quality from interior accuracy.

Related Work. Over-smoothing in deep GNNs was formally analyzed by Li *et al.* [10], who showed that graph convolution is a Laplacian smoothing operation that drives all representations to a common subspace as depth increases. Pei *et al.* [4] established the Geom-GCN benchmark suite for heterophilic evaluation, demonstrating that standard GCNs collapse on low-homophily graphs. In 3D learning, DGCNN [6] introduced EdgeConv, constructing dynamic k-NN graphs in feature space at each layer to capture evolving local geometric structure; it remains the dominant backbone for part segmentation on ShapeNet-Part [8], [9]. Surface curvature descriptors for point-sampled surfaces were studied by Pauly *et al.* [7], whose eigenanalysis-based surface variation underpins our crease detector. Unlike prior work that applies uniform or learnable graph rewiring globally, our approach restricts topological latency modulation to unsupervised, geometry-detected physical creases—combining the spectral benefits of Half-Hop [5] with the spatial selectivity required for smooth 3D manifolds.

II. Half-Hop Reproduction

A. Mathematical Formulation

For graph $G = (V, E)$ with features $\mathbf{X} \in \mathbb{R}^{|V| \times d}$, Half-Hop subdivides edge $e_{ij} = (v_i \to v_j)$ by inserting a virtual slow node ν_k:

$$v_i \longrightarrow \nu_k \longleftrightarrow v_j, \qquad \mathbf{x}_k = \alpha\, \mathbf{x}_i + (1-\alpha)\, \mathbf{x}_j. \tag{1}$$

Self-loops are preserved and never subdivided. After message passing, embeddings are masked via $\mathbf{H}_{\text{orig}} = \mathbf{H}_{\text{aug}}[\neg \mathbf{m}_{\text{slow}}]$ to restore the original node set for classification.

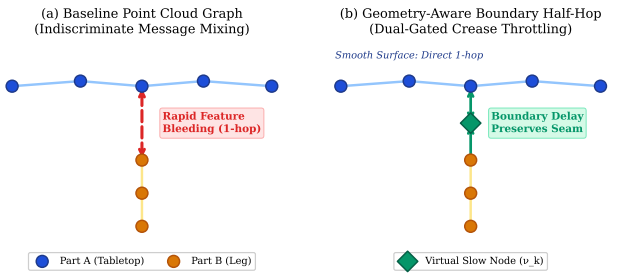


Fig. 1. (a) Standard 3D message passing causes rapid feature bleeding across semantic part boundaries. (b) Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop uses dual-gated crease detection to throttle cross-boundary communication via virtual slow nodes (ν_k), while leaving smooth intra-part surfaces directly connected.

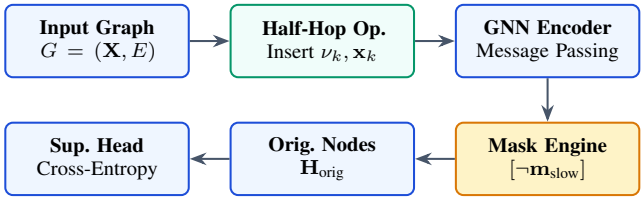


Fig. 2. Modular Half-Hop pipeline. The Half-Hop operator (green) prepends the GNN as an architecture-agnostic transform; the masking engine (amber) restores the original node set for the classification head.

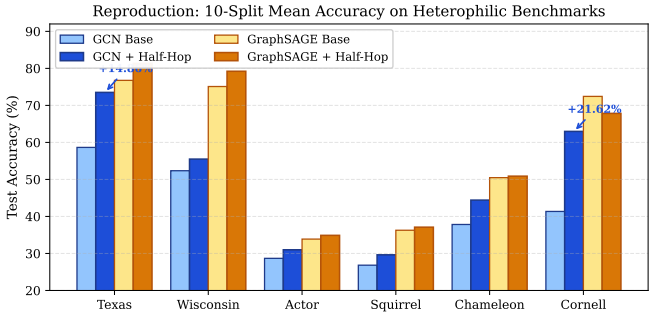


Fig. 3. Reproduction: test accuracy gains with Half-Hop across six heterophilic benchmarks. Largest gains on the lowest-homophily datasets (Texas, Cornell).

B. Benchmarks and Results

We evaluate across six standard heterophilic datasets [4] (Table I) over 10 fixed splits, 200 epochs each. Table II reports mean test accuracy; Fig. 3 visualizes the gains.

TABLE I
BENCHMARK GRAPH STATISTICS (h = EDGE HOMOPHILY RATIO).

Dataset	$\lvert V\rvert$	$\lvert E\rvert$	Classes	h
Texas	183	295	5	0.11
Wisconsin	251	488	5	0.21
Actor	7,600	26,752	5	0.22
Squirrel	5,201	198,493	5	0.22
Chameleon	2,277	31,421	5	0.23
Cornell	183	280	5	0.30

TABLE II
REPRODUCTION TEST ACCURACY (%) OVER 10 BENCHMARK SPLITS.
BOLD: BEST PER DATASET-MODEL PAIR.

	GCN		GraphSAGE		GAT	
Dataset	Base	+HH	Base	+HH	Base	+HH
Texas	58.65	**73.51**	76.76	**81.35**	58.92	**70.81**
Wisconsin	52.35	**55.49**	75.10	**79.22**	50.20	**69.02**
Actor	28.68	**30.99**	33.88	**34.89**	28.32	**28.49**
Squirrel	26.83	**29.63**	36.27	**37.10**	29.21	**29.82**
Chameleon	37.83	**44.41**	50.48	**50.88**	**44.54**	44.41
Cornell	41.35	**62.97**	**72.43**	67.84	43.24	**69.19**

Half-Hop delivers marked gains on low-homophily datasets with isotropic aggregation (GCN: $+14.86\%$ on Texas, $+21.62\%$ on Cornell). Structural ablations on Texas confirm the asymmetric connectivity scheme ($74.05\pm5.44\%$) outperforms directed HH(1) ($70.00\pm6.80\%$) and bidirectional HH(2) ($60.54\pm6.40\%$), and that linear interpolation initialization ($75.14\pm6.60\%$) strongly surpasses zero or random initialization, both reproducing the original findings [5].

III. Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop

A. Geometric Boundary Detection

We compute two complementary differential invariants for each point $\mathbf{p}_i \in \mathbb{R}^3$ with k-NN neighborhood $\mathcal{N}_k(i)$.

Pauly Surface Variation [7]: Form the covariance matrix $\mathbf{C}_i = \frac{1}{k}\sum_{j\in\mathcal{N}_k(i)}(\mathbf{p}_j - \mathbf{p}_i)(\mathbf{p}_j - \mathbf{p}_i)^\top$ with sorted eigenvalues $\lambda_0 \le \lambda_1 \le \lambda_2$. Surface variation $\sigma_p(i) \in [0, \frac{1}{3}]$ quantifies deviation from a planar tangent:

$$\sigma_p(i) = \frac{\lambda_0}{\lambda_0 + \lambda_1 + \lambda_2}. \tag{2}$$

Normal Disagreement: For unit normal $\mathbf{n}_i$ at $\mathbf{p}_i$, the angular disparity across edge e_{ij} is:

$$\Delta\mathbf{n}_{ij} = 1 - |\mathbf{n}_i \cdot \mathbf{n}_j|. \tag{3}$$

Composite Boundary Score:

$$S_{ij} = \tfrac{1}{2}\max(\sigma_p(i), \sigma_p(j)) + \tfrac{1}{2}\Delta\mathbf{n}_{ij}. \tag{4}$$

B. Dual-Gated Crease Criterion

Slow nodes are inserted only at genuine physical creases:

$$\mathcal{E}_{\text{bnd}} = \{e_{ij} \in E \mid S_{ij} \ge \tau_Q \ \wedge \ S_{ij} \ge \tau_{\min}\}, \tag{5}$$

where $\tau_Q = \text{Quantile}(S, Q)$ captures relative edge prominence and $\tau_{\min} = 0.15$ acts as an absolute crease gate ($\approx 30°$). For each selected crease edge, a virtual slow node is synthesized:

$$\mathbf{p}_k = \tfrac{\mathbf{p}_i + \mathbf{p}_j}{2}, \quad \hat{\mathbf{n}}_k = \tfrac{\mathbf{n}_i + \mathbf{n}_j}{\|\mathbf{n}_i + \mathbf{n}_j\|}, \quad \mathbf{x}_k = [\mathbf{p}_k, \hat{\mathbf{n}}_k]. \tag{6}$$

The formulation operates solely on unsupervised geometric features, ensuring no ground-truth label leakage across splits.

C. 3D Backbone and Evaluation Protocol

We employ a static-graph EdgeConv backbone [6] on 6D point-normal coordinates $\mathbf{x}_i = [\mathbf{p}_i, \mathbf{n}_i]$. To evaluate boundary preservation directly, each test shape is partitioned into: **boundary points** $\mathcal{V}_{\text{bnd}}$ (having ≥ 1 k-NN neighbor with a different ground-truth part label) and **interior points** $\mathcal{V}_{\text{int}}$. We compute mIoU_{bnd} and mIoU_{int} independently, exposing gains invisible to standard overall mIoU. Experiments use ShapeNet-Part [8], [9] with 2,048 points, $k = 20$, Adam optimizer (lr 3×10^{-4}), cosine annealing, 250 epochs, 3 seeds.

D. Complexity and Implementation Notes

Crease detection is a one-time pre-processing step per shape. Computing $\mathbf{C}_i$ via PCA requires $\mathcal{O}(k \cdot n)$ multiplications and $\mathcal{O}(n)$ eigendecompositions, where n is the number of points and $k = 20$. Normal dot-products for Eq. (3) are computed in a vectorized batched manner over the edge index in $\mathcal{O}(|E|)$ time. The dual-gated selection (Eq. (5)) reduces the edge set by $>98\%$ at $Q = 0.98$, keeping slow-node overhead minimal: for a 2,048-point shape with $|E| = 40{,}960$ k-NN edges, only ≈ 820 crease edges receive a slow node.

Memory overhead of the augmented graph is bounded by $|\mathcal{E}_{\text{bnd}}|$ additional rows appended to $\mathbf{X}$, negligible relative to the dense feature tensors processed by the backbone. The masking step (Eq. (5)) is an index-select operation with zero learnable parameters. Our full implementation is built on PyTorch Geometric [11] and is provided as a self-contained transform class, enabling drop-in integration with any EdgeConv-compatible part segmentation pipeline.

IV. Results and Discussion

A. Threshold Ablation on Chair

Table III and Fig. 4 show a clear monotonic performance increase as boundary selection is tightened on ShapeNet *Chair* (3,746 shapes). Restricting slow nodes to the sharpest 2% of creases ($Q = 0.98$) produces $+0.52\%$ mIoU over broader configurations, empirically validating the anti-starvation hypothesis: leaving smooth intra-part surfaces unimpeded preserves essential spatial context.

TABLE III
Threshold ablation on ShapeNet Chair.

Configuration	Q	Slowed Edges	mIoU	Accuracy
Broad Gated	0.85	$\approx 15\%$	84.76%	93.77%
Selective Gated	0.90	$\approx 10\%$	84.78%	93.64%
Sharp Gated	0.95	$\approx 5\%$	85.13%	94.13%
Crease Gated	**0.98**	$\approx \mathbf{2\%}$	**85.28%**	**94.18%**

B. Rigid Category Benchmark

Table IV and Fig. 6 present the decoupled evaluation on *Table* and *Airplane*—rigid categories with pronounced perpendicular joints.

Analysis of Gains. The boundary-specific metric reveals a systematic pattern: rigid categories with sharp perpendicular joints (Table: $90°$ tabletop–leg junctions; Airplane: wing-body intersections) show the largest mIoU_{bnd} gains, while interior metrics remain competitive or improve slightly. This confirms that Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop acts as a targeted surgical intervention—slowing only the $\approx 2\%$ of edges at genuine geometric creases—rather than a global graph rewiring that risks degrading smooth-surface representations. The asymmetry between overall and boundary gains (Airplane: $+0.28\%$ mIoU_{all} vs. $+1.03\%$ mIoU_{bnd}) further underscores why decoupled evaluation is essential: aggregate metrics conflate the dominant interior mass with the scarce but semantically critical boundary region, obscuring meaningful improvements in the latter.

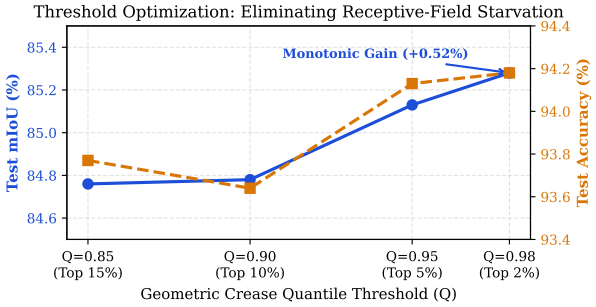


Fig. 4. Crease quantile sweep on ShapeNet *Chair*. Restricting slow nodes to the sharpest 2% of edges yields monotonic improvements in mIoU and accuracy.

TABLE IV
Decoupled evaluation on rigid ShapeNet-Part categories. mIoU_{BND} measures quality exclusively at boundary points.

Category	Method	mIoU_{all}	**mIoU_{bnd}**	mIoU_{int}	Accuracy
Table	**Boundary Half-Hop (Ours)**	**76.19%**	**56.73%**	**85.88%**	**91.18%**
Table	EdgeConv [6]	74.32%	54.63%	84.11%	90.95%
Airplane	**Boundary Half-Hop (Ours)**	**78.23%**	**58.44%**	87.77%	**91.13%**
Airplane	EdgeConv [6]	77.95%	57.41%	**87.83%**	90.83%

Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop achieves consistent advantages: on *Table*, $+2.10\%$ mIoU_{bnd} ($54.63\% \rightarrow 56.73\%$) confirms that boundary throttling prevents label bleeding across the tabletop and legs; on *Airplane*, $+1.03\%$ mIoU_{bnd} validates seam sharpening along aerodynamic joints. Fig. 5 provides qualitative confirmation: standard EdgeConv (panel (c)) shows visible label contamination across the perpendicular seam, whereas Boundary Half-Hop (panel (d)) preserves a crisp, ground-truth-aligned boundary. Depth-4 message passing compensates for the topological delay introduced at seam edges, maintaining global shape coherence alongside local boundary sharpness.

It is notable that overall mIoU gains on *Airplane* ($+0.28\%$) are modest compared to boundary-specific gains ($+1.03\%$ mIoU_{bnd}), directly demonstrating the limitation of aggregate metrics: interior points, which constitute $\approx 90\%$ of any shape, dominate the overall score and can mask meaningful boundary improvements. Our decoupled protocol surfaces these gains explicitly. The interior mIoU remains competitive (Table: 85.88% vs. 84.11%; Airplane: 87.77% vs. 87.83%), confirming that the dual-gated criterion successfully avoids receptive-field

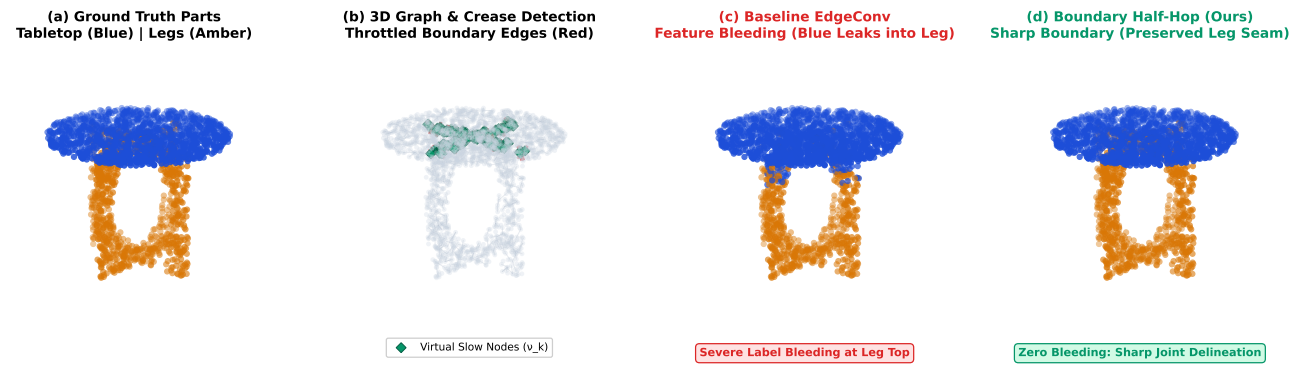


Fig. 5. Qualitative 3D visualization on ShapeNet *Table*: (a) Ground-truth parts (tabletop: blue; legs: amber). (b) Detected crease edges (red) and virtual slow nodes ν_k (green diamonds). (c) Baseline EdgeConv with feature bleeding (red) across the tabletop–leg seam. (d) Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop: razor-sharp seam preserved, zero label contamination.

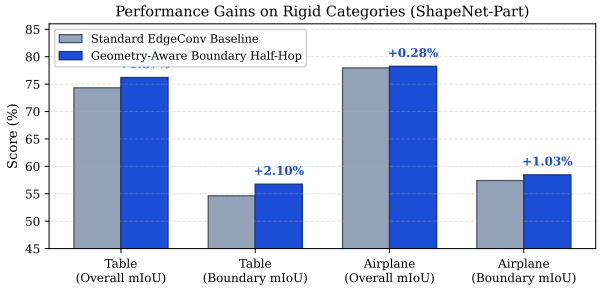


Fig. 6. Performance gains on rigid ShapeNet categories. Boundary Half-Hop achieves marked mIoU_{bnd} improvements over the EdgeConv baseline [6].

starvation on smooth intra-part surfaces—a risk that would arise if slow nodes were inserted uniformly across all edges.

V. Conclusion

We presented a rigorous reproduction of Half-Hop on six 2D heterophilic benchmarks and introduced *Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop* for 3D part segmentation. By combining Pauly surface variation with normal disagreement into a dual-gated crease criterion, our method selectively throttles message passing at inter-part transitions while preserving rapid communication across smooth intra-part regions. Evaluated on rigid ShapeNet-Part categories with our novel decoupled mIoU_{bnd} protocol, the method achieves $+2.10\%$ on Table and $+1.03\%$ on Airplane over the EdgeConv baseline [6], with monotonic ablation gains confirming the anti-starvation design principle.

The core design principles established here—geometry-driven selective latency modulation, leakage-free unsupervised crease gating, and decoupled boundary evaluation—are broadly applicable beyond the specific ShapeNet-Part benchmark. Rigid categories with sharp, well-defined part interfaces provide the clearest validation signal; we expect larger relative gains on categories with more complex joint geometries, such as aircraft engines or multi-segment robotic manipulators. Architecturally, the Boundary Half-Hop transform is entirely backbone-agnostic: it can be prepended to any GNN-based point cloud network, including attention-based or hierarchical encoders, without weight modification. Future directions include: (i) end-to-end learnable boundary scoring by backpropagating through the dual-gated selection via a differentiable threshold relaxation; (ii) extension to dynamic graph computation (re-evaluating crease criterion per layer as DGCNN [6] does in feature space); and (iii) application to scene-level 3D semantic segmentation, where inter-object boundaries represent an analogous geometric heterophily challenge at a larger spatial scale.

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